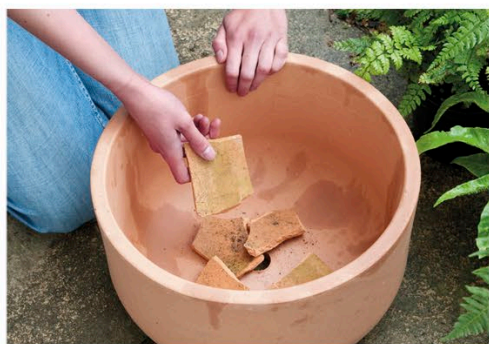


CONTAINERS

When planting in containers, choose the ones large enough for your plants, and ensure they have drainage holes in the base. Bear in mind that, because they hold greater volumes of soil and water, large pots need watering less frequently than small ones. Also consider the material the container is made of. Choose frost-proof terra-cotta and lightweight materials, such as plastic or resin, for balconies and roof gardens.



Ensuring good drainage Place pieces of broken terra-cotta pots or polystyrene to prevent the soil from falling through while keeping the holes clear for drainage.



Filling with soil Add an even layer of potting soil over the broken pots, selecting the correct type for your particular plant. Also add some slow-release fertilizer.



Planting your selections Having first watered the plants, remove them from their pots and place them on the potting soil. Fill in around the plants and press gently.



Aftercare Leave a 2in (5cm) gap between the top of the soil and the rim of the pot to make watering easier. Water regularly, especially in summer. Topdress annually.

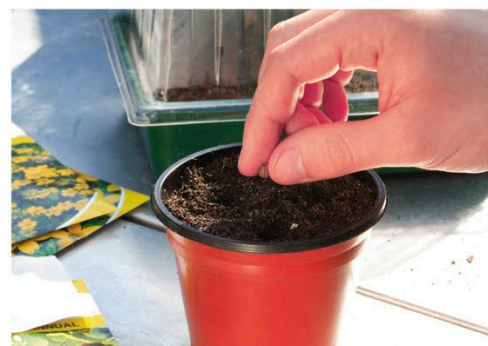
SEEDS

Growing annuals and vegetables from seeds is both rewarding and usually cheaper than buying mature plants. Growing perennial, trees, and shrubs by seeds can also be rewarding though often take more time and can require special efforts.

To sow indoors, fill a clean seed tray or pot with seed-starting mix, and press down gently. Water using a can fitted with a rose nozzle, then let drain. Sprinkle seeds thinly on the soil surface. Check the seed package for the required planting depth, and cover the seeds with sifted mix to that depth. Label the tray or pot, and cover with plastic. Place in a warm, lit area, such as a windowsill, and let the seeds germinate. Keep the soil moist, and remove the cover as soon as the seedlings emerge. Continue growing the seedlings indoors and transfer to larger pots as they grow. Acclimate them to the outdoors before planting them after the risk of frost has passed.



Using pots for large seeds Fill a small pot with potting soil, firm gently, and make holes to the depth indicated on the seed package.



Sowing the seeds Drop a seed into each hole, cover with potting soil, and water well. Cover with a clear plastic bag.



Growing the seedlings Once your seedlings have a few leaves, transfer them individually into modular trays or small pots.



Potting the seedlings Plant one seedling per module or pot, press them in gently, and water well. Continue to grow them under cover.